Measurement of Inequality and Discrimination

Week 4: Discrimination II

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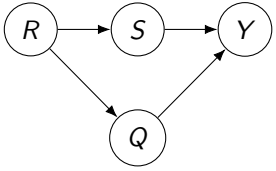
November 2, 2026

Weinberger (2023)

Weinberger (2023): "*Signal manipulation and the causal analysis of racial discrimination*"

- The **problem**: causal methods ask what happens if we change a cause while keeping everything else fixed. But can we change *only* someone's race? (p. 1264)
- Three answers in the literature:
  1. change the decision-maker's *perception* of race (Greiner & Rubin, 2011);
  2. race is a bundle of components; change the components (Sen and Wasow 2016);
  3. counterfactual tests are unsuitable for discrimination (Kohler-Hausmann 2018).

Signal manipulation

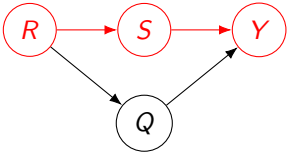


R: race, S: name on the CV,
Q: qualifications, Y: callback

- The experiment does not change race R, but a **signal** S for race.
- The name should *reliably track* race.

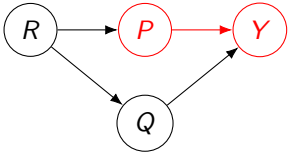
Signals and perceptions

Signals (Weinberger)



S: signal of race (name on the CV)

Perceptions (Greiner & Rubin)



P: perception of race

R: race, Q: qualifications, Y: callback

The discriminatory path is coloured red.

Royals (Weinberger, 2023, pp. 1273–74)

Kohler-Hausmann's example: a society of Royals and Non-Royals. Royals wear purple capes and carry sticks. Non-Royals step off the sidewalk when a Royal approaches.

- Kohler-Hausmann: the Non-Royal steps into the road "because she encountered a Royal", not a cape-wearer.
- Weinberger: but giving a Non-Royal a cape and stick and seeing whether others step aside is still "a perfectly good test" of discrimination in this context.

Questions about Weinberger (2023)

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Standard and causal discrimination

Y discriminates against X on the basis of a characteristic C (race, gender, ...):

Standard (1) Y treats X worse than Y would treat a **suitable comparator** without C, and (2) this is *because of* C.

Causal Y treats X worse *because of* C. (No comparator needed.)

Both need an answer to the question: what exactly is the **cause**?

- Call the causes that count as discriminatory C-**events**.
- Different accounts of discrimination give different answers.

Accounts of *C*-events

Account	**The cause of interest**	**Defended by**
characteristic but-for	*X* has *C*	Eyer (2021)
perception	*Y* perceives *X* to have *C*	Greiner and Rubin (2011); Eidelson (2015)
conscious motivation	*Y* uses a *C*-related *reason* to treat *X* worse	Shin (2010); Hu (2026)
(un)conscious motivation	*C* plays a role in *Y*'s motivation, possibly unconsciously	Krieger (1995)
acting on a category	*Y* acts on a stereotype or social meaning of *C*	Dembroff and Kohler-Hausmann (2022)
signal manipulation	*X* emits a signal of *C*	Weinberger (2023)

Characteristic versus perception

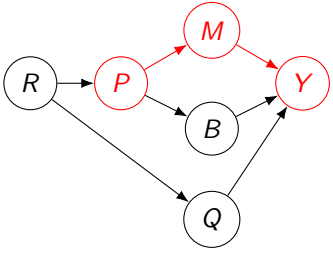


R_1/R_2: race early in life/shortly before the decision, Q: qualifications, P: perceived race, Y: hired

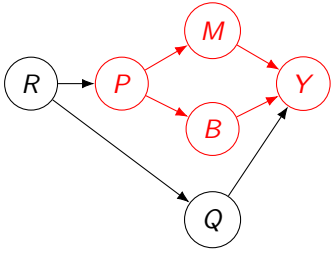
- But-for: would X have been hired if R_2 had been white, holding Q fixed?
- Perception: would X have been hired if the employer had *perceived* X as white?
- ? **Modularity**: R_2 and Q are indexed at the same moment. Can we change race at t_2 while everything else at t_2 stays the same?

Conscious versus unconscious motivation

Conscious motivation



(Un)conscious motivation



M: a race-related reason, B: unconscious bias; R, P, Q, Y as before

Concepts around equality of opportunity

1. Meritocracy
   "The job should go to the applicant who is best qualified."
   "Economic benefits should be rewarded proportional to societal contribution."
2. Desertism
   "Poor people don't deserve their fate."
   "People who work hard deserve greater rewards."
3. Equality of Opportunity
   "It should be possible to achieve success regardless of background."
   "Institutions should not discriminate on the basis of race and gender."

Equality of Opportunity

- Formal equality of opportunity
  - Civil Rights Act of 1964
  - Article 14 of the ECHR, Article 21 CFREU
- Substantive equality of opportunity
- Radical equality of opportunity / Luck egalitarianism



Luck egalitarianism

1. *"Circumstances" should not causally affect the attainment of economic benefits.*
2. *"Matters of responsibility" should affect the attainment of economic benefits.*

- **Circumstances**: social class, geographical area, ethnicity, etc.
  or: anything outside one's control
- **Matters of responsibility**: effort, choices

Reading: Roemer (1998, chs. 1–3)

- Equal opportunity "levels the playing field": before the competition, opportunities are equalised; after it, individuals are accountable (pp. 1–2).
- Society divides people into **types**: groups with the same circumstances. Which circumstances count is a political choice (pp. 7–8).
- Roemer's rule: equalise outcomes across types for people who exert the same **degree of effort**, measured by their percentile *within* their type (p. 15).

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